

Art Spector, first player signed to play for the Celtics; at 70

By Neil Singelais
Globe Staff

The "Original Celtic" is dead. Art Spector, the first player Walter Brown signed to a Celtics contract when the Boston franchise joined the newly organized Basketball Association of America for the 1946-47 season, died Thursday night in New York after a long illness. He was 70.

Mr. Spector, a 6-foot-4-inch, 200-pound forward who spent four years with the Celtics (1946-50), was best known as a defensive specialist. He played in the Celtics' first home game at Boston Arena before 4,329 fans on Nov. 5, 1946, scoring 4 points in a 57-55 loss to the Chicago Stags. Honey Russell was the coach, and Mr. Spector's teammates included Chuck Connors, John Simmons, Red Wallace and Wyndol Gray. He played in an era when the two-handed set shot was in vogue.

"Art was a steady player who could run and rebound," said Connors, star of "The Rifleman" TV series, who now lives in Los Angeles. "He was the soft-spoken guy on our team, and I was the big mouth with all the wisecracks. He was always under control. He smiled when I joked. He was a great audience."

Mr. Spector, who was paid \$4,000 in his first season with the Celtics, said in a recent interview that his assignment "was to dog the other team's best player. It was rough then under the boards, but it's even rougher for today's players. I had some memorable games against such proficient scorers as Philadelphia's Joe Fulks and Howie Dallmar."

The Celtics in those early days had difficulty selling the sport. Mr. Spector and his teammates often ran clinics at local schools to promote the game, and they didn't get paid extra for their efforts.

What is not well known is that Mr. Spector had a hand in breaking the NBA racial barrier. He became a scout for the Celtics after his playing days and helped to recruit Chuck Cooper, the first black player to be drafted by Boston (1950).

Mr. Spector's last visit to Boston was in April to take part in a reunion of the 1957 Celtics, the city's first NBA championship team.

"I'd love to be playing today," Mr. Spector said then. "Hey, I was part of that one time, and it was an experience not many men have the opportunity to enjoy. It was a great life, and I met many great

people in the sports world."

The Celtics were the only pro team for which he played. He was the first to wear No. 12, since worn by nine other Celtics, the latest being Jerry Sichting.

Mr. Spector, a native of Philadelphia, lived in Newtown, Conn., for the past 30 years. He was employed for many years as a manufacturer's representative for a ski clothing company. In recent years, he was involved in the landscaping business.

He leaves his wife, Stella Josephine (Kuhlman); four sons, Arthur of Chicago, Victor of Hilltown, Pa., Toby of Jacksonville, Fla., and John of Newtown, Conn.; and three daughters, Amy Bretholz of New York, Katherine Miller of Las Vegas and Ann Elizabeth of Newtown, Conn.

A funeral will be held at 1 p.m. Monday, June 22, in Newtown Congregational Church.

Charles Pingree

Retired bank official; at 72

A memorial service will be held at 11 a.m. on Wednesday, June 24, in Pilgrim Congregational Church in Duxbury for Charles A. Pingree, 72, retired senior vice president of the Old Colony Trust Division of First National Bank of Boston.

Mr. Pingree died Thursday in his home in Duxbury after a brief illness.

Born in Haverhill, he graduated from Phillips Academy in Andover and from Dartmouth College in 1937. He received his master's degree from the Amos Tuck School of Business Administration at Dartmouth in 1938.

Mr. Pingree started out as a security analyst in the Old Colony Trust Division in 1941 and became a vice president of the division in 1948. He retired in 1978 as senior vice president.

An Army veteran of World War II, Mr. Pingree was past president of the Boston Security Analysts Society and was secretary-treasurer of the Bay State Seniors Golf Association. He was a former treasurer of the Duxbury Yacht Club and past treasurer of the trustees of Partridge Academy in Duxbury. He was a past member of Trout Unlimited, Ducks Unlimited and the Audubon Society.

He leaves his wife, Elinor (Percey); two sons, Charles A. Jr. of Plymouth and Karlton P. Pingree of Essex; and a grandson, Charles Hazen Pingree of Plymouth.

Clipped By:

josean_martinez

Thu, Jul 30, 2020